Congestion pricing is cutting traffic. Where should transit improve next?

What the first six months show, and a step-by-step plan for outer-borough commuters

October 2026

Better transit could move more people out of cars; we recommend testing it first in Eastern Queens

WHAT HAS HAPPENED

Congestion pricing is reducing traffic. About 67,000 fewer vehicles a day (11% fewer) entered the congestion zone in the first six months. Highway speeds across the city changed by less than half a mile an hour.

WHAT IS STILL WRONG

Many outer-borough commuters still drive, and their transit trips are long. In the three areas we studied, 42% to 57% of workers drive to work alone. Estimated transit trips to Manhattan take 56 to 71 minutes, and 13 to 22 of those minutes are spent walking and waiting.

WHAT WE RECOMMEND

Test it, starting in Eastern Queens. No current data can show how many drivers would switch, so a pilot should measure it. In a what-if test, trips from six Union Turnpike starting points to Midtown East at 8 a.m. were 6.2 to 12.5 minutes shorter.

Decision requested: approve the first phase in Eastern Queens, and add the Fresh Meadows and Throggs Neck buses to regular speed tracking.

Next: the four questions this briefing answers.

Sources: MTA six-month tolling report (2025); NYC DOT speed data; U.S. Census employment data (2023) and American Community Survey (2018–2022); trip-planner model.

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This briefing answers four questions, one after another

01	**What has congestion pricing changed so far?** Traffic into the zone, and who travels to Manhattan	Slides 4–5
02	**Where does transit still fall short, and why?** Three areas, door-to-door trip times and local bus performance	Slides 6–8
03	**What should be built, and where?** A fix for each area, and a what-if test on Union Turnpike	Slides 9–10
04	**In what order, and what is decided today?** A three-phase plan, three decisions and the first 90 days	Slides 11–12

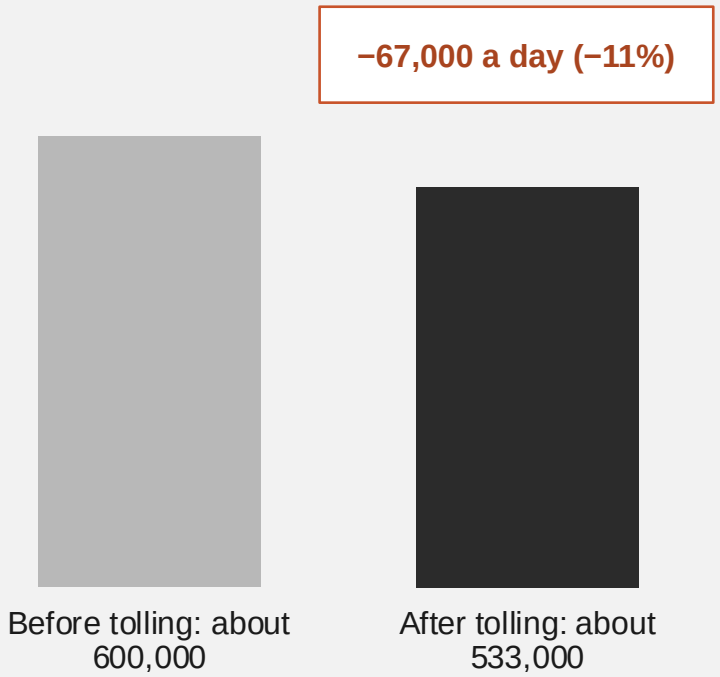
Appendix: how highway speeds changed after tolling (slide 13)

Next: what congestion pricing has changed so far.

Congestion pricing cut the number of vehicles entering the zone by about 11% in six months

Vehicles entering Manhattan south of 60th Street. Left: the official before-and-after estimate. Right: 2025 weekday counts at each crossing.

Vehicles entering the zone each day



Where vehicles enter: average weekday entries, 2025



Busiest crossings

East 60th Street	**79,500**
FDR Drive	**53,000**
Lincoln Tunnel	**46,800**
Queens Midtown Tunnel	**46,500**
West Side Highway	**45,900**
Holland Tunnel	**41,400**

The two busiest crossings carry 26% of entries

Circle size = weekday entries

Next: who travels into Manhattan, and how.

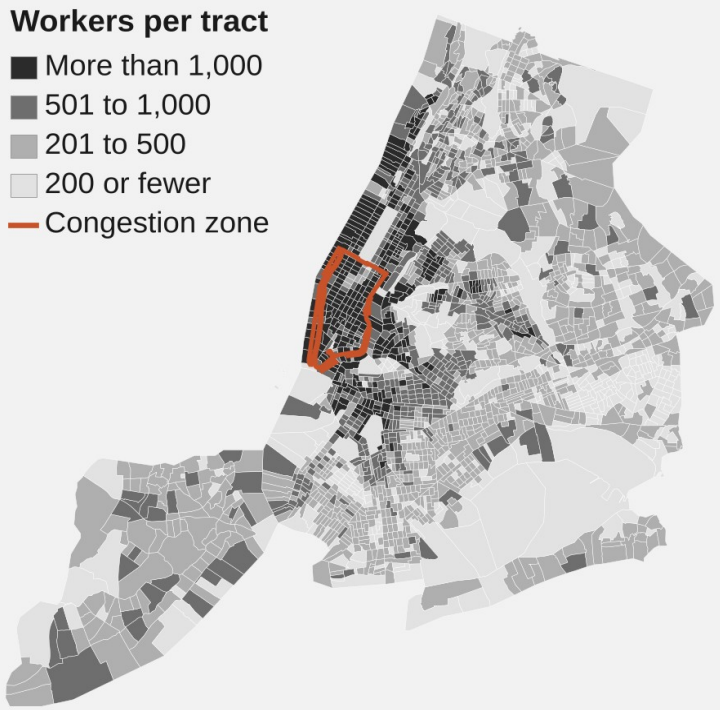
Sources: MTA six-month tolling report; New York State open data on crossing counts, 5 January to 30 June 2025. Crossing counts (511,829 a weekday) use a different method, so they do not add up to the official totals.

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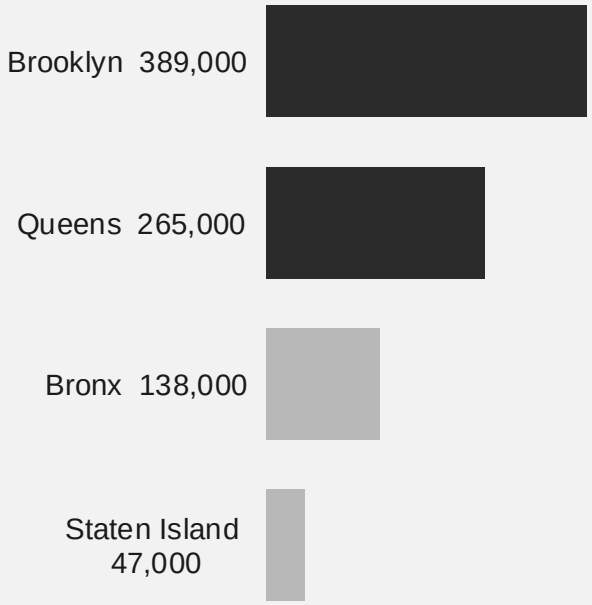
Most zone workers come from Brooklyn and Queens, but the Bronx sends the most cars into Manhattan

Left: where people who work in the zone live. Middle: zone jobs by home borough. Right: car-driver trips into Manhattan each day.

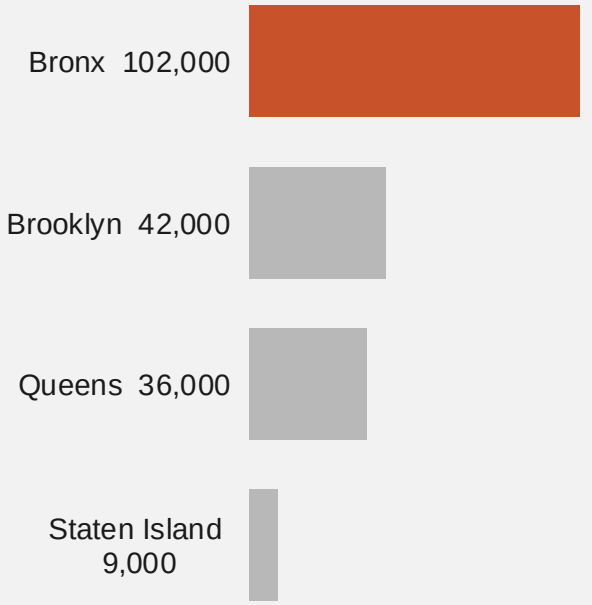
Where zone workers live



Zone jobs held by New Yorkers, by home borough (Brooklyn and Queens: 53%)



Car trips into Manhattan each day: the Bronx has 2.8 times as many as Queens



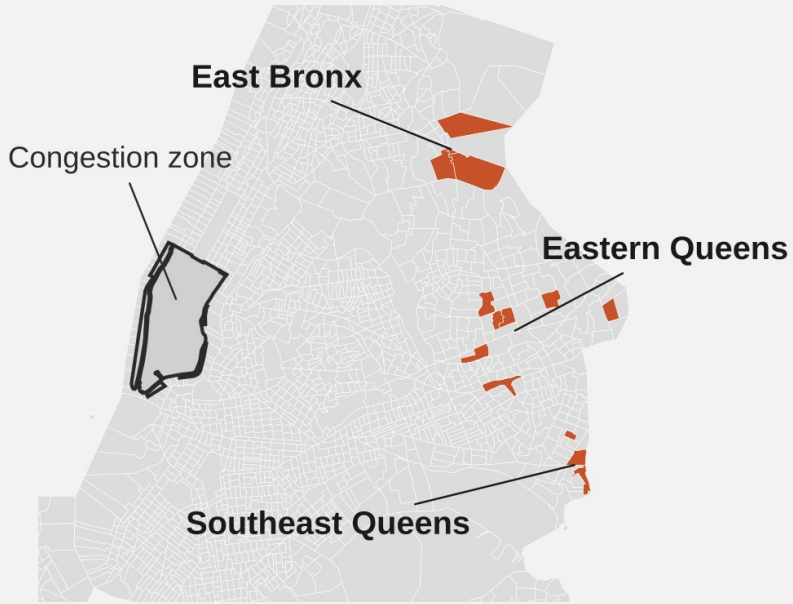
Next: three outer-borough areas where driving, Manhattan jobs and long transit trips overlap.

Sources: U.S. Census employment data, 2023 (payroll jobs; Manhattan residents hold a further 401,000 zone jobs); NYC DOT Citywide Mobility Survey, 2024. Survey trips go to all of Manhattan, not only the zone.

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Three outer-borough areas have many zone workers, a lot of driving and long transit trips

We chose areas around the corridors where we have trip results. Eastern Queens has the most zone workers; the East Bronx has the most solo drivers. They are places to test, not proven hotspots.



Area	Residents who work in the zone (share of working residents)	Drive to work alone	Example transit trip to Manhattan, and main barrier
Eastern Queens Union Turnpike and Fresh Meadows	2,649 (28%)	30–60% by neighbourhood; about 42% overall	55.6 minutes; long walks to the bus
East Bronx Throggs Neck and Pelham Bay	1,454 (29%)	50–81% by neighbourhood; about 57% overall	71.2 minutes; a slow 16-minute local bus ride
Southeast Queens Rosedale and Laurelton	651 (27%)	50–60% by neighbourhood; about 52% overall	61.9 minutes; an outdoor transfer and a second fare

Strongest case on demand
Eastern Queens has 2,649 residents who work in the zone, almost twice as many as the East Bronx.

Strongest case on car use
The East Bronx has the most people driving alone (57%), and its local bus is slow and often late.

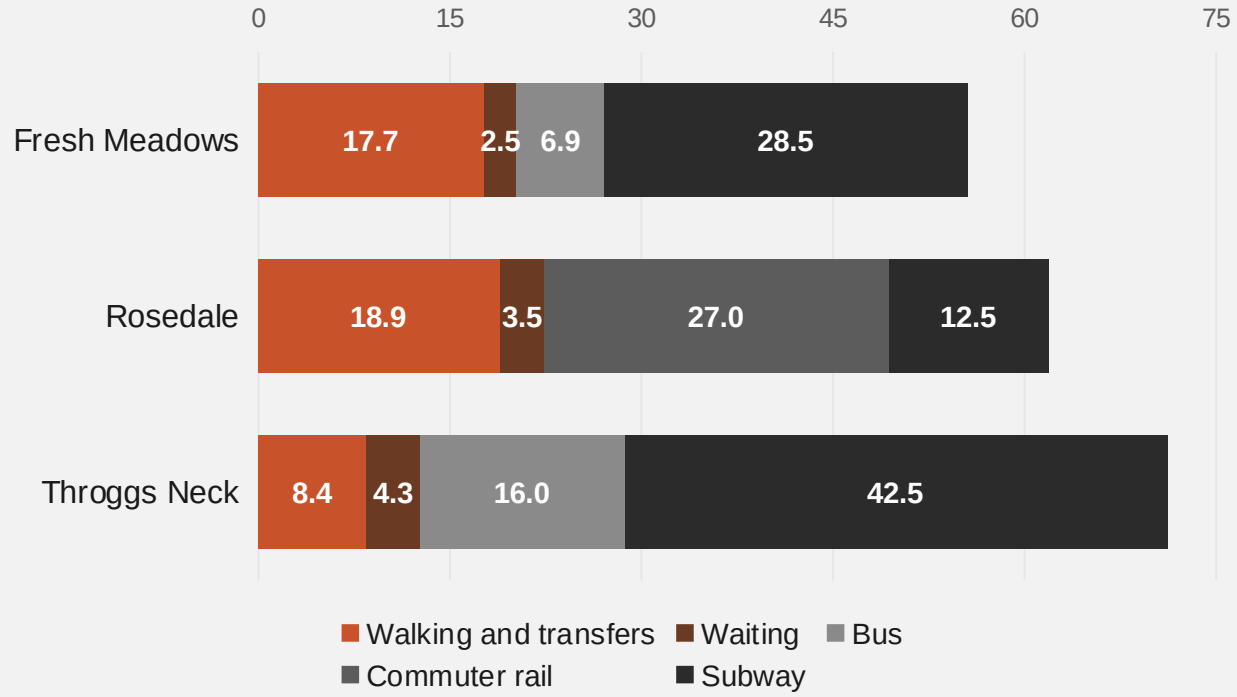
Next: how long transit trips from these areas really take.

Sources: U.S. Census employment data (2023), American Community Survey (2018–2022), trip-planner model. No public data shows where toll-paying drivers live, so this shows where zone jobs and driving overlap. Drive-alone rates cover all commutes.

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From these areas, a transit trip to Manhattan takes about an hour, and 13 to 22 minutes of it is walking and waiting

Estimated trips leaving at 8 a.m. on a Wednesday (fall 2026 timetable); modelled, not measured. Fresh Meadows is shown with the bus to the F train; slide 10 tests the Union Turnpike bus.



Fresh Meadows to Midtown East — **55.6 min**

Walking and waiting: 20.2 min

Walking alone takes 17.7 minutes. The bus ride is only 6.9 minutes, so bus lanes alone will not fix the problem.

Rosedale to Lower Manhattan — **61.9 min**

Walking and waiting: 22.4 min

The Long Island Rail Road part is fast (27 minutes), but changing to the subway adds an outdoor walk and a second fare.

Throggs Neck to Grand Central — **71.2 min**

Walking and waiting: 12.7 min

The local bus on Crosby Avenue takes 16 minutes. It is slow (7.9 mph) and on time only 67% of the time at peak.

Next: how the local buses that feed these trips perform.

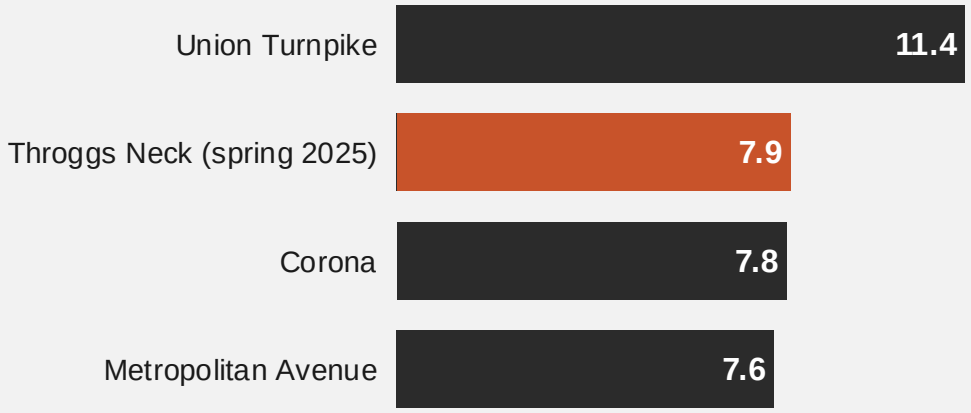
Source: trip-planner model using MTA fall 2026 timetables. Driving times are not shown because they are not calibrated.

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The local buses differ: the Throggs Neck bus is slow and often late, while the Fresh Meadows bus is on time

MTA bus data, weekday mornings. Left: average bus speed. Right: share of buses on time at peak, against the MTA's 70% target.

Average morning bus speed (mph)



The Union Turnpike bus is the one in our what-if test. It is the fastest and most reliable route shown.

The Fresh Meadows bus has no speed record in the data.

Buses on time at peak (%)



What this means: In Fresh Meadows the bus is on time and the ride is only 6.9 minutes, so better walking routes come first. In Throggs Neck the bus is slow and below target, so a bus lane on Crosby Avenue is the fix.

Next: what we propose to fix in each area.

Sources: MTA bus speeds, weekdays 7–10 a.m. (August 2026; Throggs Neck March–June 2025); MTA wait assessment, August 2026. On time means the gap between buses is no more than 3 minutes longer than scheduled. Orange = below target or the focus route.

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Each area has a different main problem, so each needs a different fix

One main barrier and one main fix per place. Phase 1 starts first; Phase 2 follows once Phase 1 is reviewed. By law, toll revenue pays only for physical and technology projects, so every fix is of that kind.

Place	Main barrier	What to build	Phase
Fresh Meadows Eastern Queens	Long walks to the bus (the bus itself is short and on time)	Safer, shorter walks to the bus stops, and better shelters	1
Union Turnpike Eastern Queens	A long bus ride (14 to 41 minutes) and an 8-minute transfer	Bus lanes and signal priority for the Union Turnpike bus, and a sheltered transfer at Kew Gardens	1
Throggs Neck East Bronx	A slow, often late local bus (7.9 mph; 67% on time)	A bus lane and signal priority on Crosby Avenue, after a 2026 speed check	2
Rosedale Southeast Queens	An outdoor transfer and a second fare	A covered walkway between the Long Island Rail Road and the A train at Nostrand Avenue, and a cheaper transfer fare	2

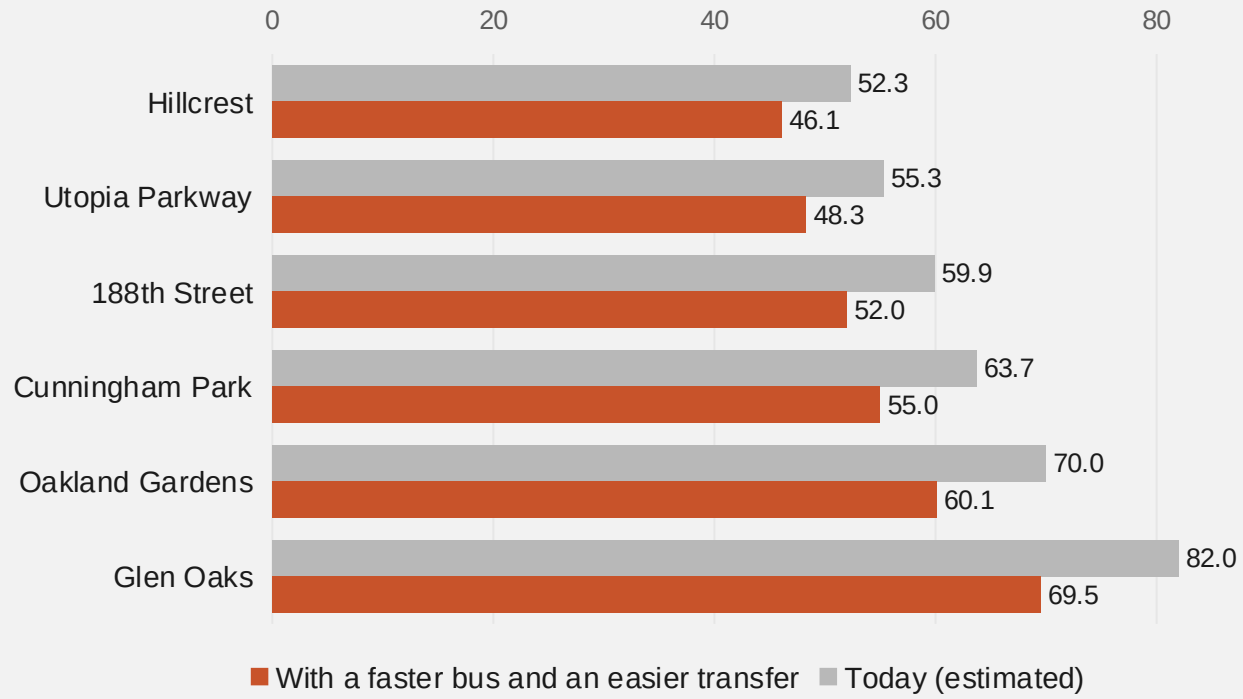
Next: how much time a faster bus would save in each area.

Sources: U.S. Census employment data (2023) and American Community Survey (2018–2022); trip-planner model; what-if model.

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A faster bus saves the most time on Union Turnpike: 6 to 12.5 minutes a trip, against about 4 in Throggs Neck

Six starting points along Union Turnpike to Midtown East, leaving at 8 a.m. Today the bus ride is 14 to 41 minutes of each trip. A what-if estimate, not a ridership forecast.



Union Turnpike

8.7 min

saved per trip on average (13.5%), if the bus runs 30% faster and the transfer takes 3 minutes less

Throggs Neck, same test

3.7 min

saved (5%), from 71.2 to 67.5 minutes. The bus is only 16 of the 71 minutes; most of the trip is on the 6 train.

What this does not show: how many drivers would switch. A pilot would measure that.

Next: the order in which we propose to make the fixes.

Source: what-if calculation on trip-planner estimates. Throggs Neck uses the bus only (its change to the train is a 3-minute walk, so no transfer saving is applied). 188th Street is a different starting point from Fresh Meadows on slide 7.

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We propose starting in Eastern Queens, then moving to the East Bronx and Southeast Queens

Each phase starts only after the review of the previous phase is passed.

	Phase 1: Eastern Queens **Months 1–12**	**Phase 2: East Bronx and Southeast Queens** **Months 12–24**	**Phase 3: Measure and expand** **Months 24–36**
Actions	Bus lanes and signal priority for the Union Turnpike bus; safer walks and shelters in Fresh Meadows; tap-to-pay readers at Kew Gardens; counts of real car trips into the zone	A bus lane on Crosby Avenue, once 2026 speed data confirm the delay; a covered transfer at Nostrand Avenue; a trial of a cheaper Long Island Rail Road to subway fare	Extend bus priority to more routes if drivers have switched; link buses to future Interborough Express stations; report results to the MTA Board
Proposed lead	NYC DOT (streets) and MTA Bus	NYC DOT, MTA construction team and Long Island Rail Road	MTA and NYC DOT
Review before the next phase	Trip times and ridership are up, and car entries from the area are down, compared with a road that did not change	The same measures, and 2026 speed data for the Crosby Avenue bus before building	Final results report

Why Eastern Queens first: It has the most residents working in the zone (2,649), and a faster bus saves the most time there (8.7 minutes a trip, against 3.7 in Throggs Neck). The East Bronx has more driving and a slow, often late bus, so it comes next, once 2026 bus speeds confirm the delay.

Next: the three decisions we ask for today.

Phases, timings and leads are proposals by the study team, for discussion.

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We ask for three decisions today so that work can start within 90 days

Left: the decisions requested from this meeting. Right: the first actions that follow.

DECISIONS REQUESTED

01 **Approve Phase 1 in Eastern Queens**

Bus priority on the Union Turnpike bus, safer walks to the bus stops in Fresh Meadows, and a better transfer at Kew Gardens.

02 **Add both local buses to speed tracking**

Track the Fresh Meadows and Throggs Neck buses monthly, and confirm the Throggs Neck delay before building in the Bronx.

03 **Agree how success will be judged**

Trip time, ridership, car entries into the zone, emissions, and change against Hillside Avenue (a road we leave unchanged), reported to the MTA Board.

NEXT 90 DAYS

Action	Proposed lead	Timing
Add the Fresh Meadows and Throggs Neck buses to monthly speed tracking	MTA Bus	Month 1
Design bus lanes and signal priority on Union Turnpike	NYC DOT	Months 1–3
Check walking routes to the bus stops in Fresh Meadows	NYC DOT	Months 1–2
Count riders, car entries and traffic on the comparison road	MTA and NYC DOT	Months 1–3
Agree which agency leads each action	MTA and NYC DOT	Months 2–3

Next: the appendix, which shows how highway speeds changed after tolling.

Phases, timings and leads are proposals by the study team, for discussion.

Highway speeds barely changed overall, and one Brooklyn-Queens Expressway stretch slowed sharply

80 road segments with good data (of 122 monitored), weekday mornings 7–10 a.m., March to June 2024 compared with 2025.



Faster by more than 2 mph	**13 segments**
Little change (within 2 mph)	**45 segments**
Slower by more than 2 mph	**22 segments**

−0.37 mph median change across the 80 segments

Brooklyn-Queens Expressway, southbound: speed fell from 42.2 to 21.5 mph (−49%). Deck repairs were under way, but this data cannot show what caused the drop.

There was no citywide gridlock, but some local bottlenecks remain.

Source: NYC DOT traffic speed data, 86 weekdays a year. Segments are kept only if they had at least 65 good days in both years.

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